

The European Renaissance

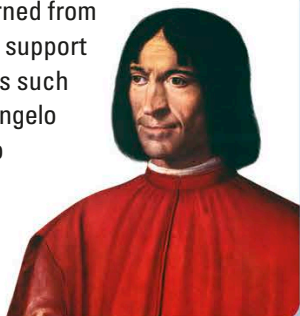
In the late medieval period, dramatic changes took place in European society, which had remained relatively unchanged for hundreds of years. New ways of thinking led to a great blossoming of culture and art. This period, lasting from the 14th to the late 16th centuries, is known as the Renaissance (meaning “rebirth”).

In the 14th century, contact with other cultures and the rediscovery of ancient texts influenced artists and thinkers. They reacted against the narrow teachings of the Church and developed a new philosophy called humanism, which valued knowledge gained through learning and experience.

The Renaissance began in Florence and other city-states of northern Italy. Painters and sculptors abandoned the flat style of medieval art in favor of depicting subjects in a more lifelike way. Rich people, eager to show off their status, began sponsoring works of art in these new styles. This led to advances in architecture, literature, science, and other areas.

LORENZO DE’ MEDICI

Lorenzo de’ Medici (1449–1492) was the most powerful man in Florence at the height of the Italian Renaissance. Known as “Lorenzo the Magnificent,” he used his vast wealth, earned from banking, to support great artists such as Michelangelo and Sandro Botticelli.



By the 15th century, Renaissance ideas had spread across Europe, helped by the development of the printing press, which introduced both new works and the writers of the ancient world to many more people. The Renaissance movement marked the end of the medieval world, and laid the foundations for the modern world.

◀ NEW ARCHITECTURE

Renaissance architects found inspiration in the buildings of ancient Greece and Rome, which often had elegant domes and columns. Designed in 1418, the dome of Florence Cathedral was the largest to be built in western Europe since Roman times.

RENAISSANCE WOMEN ▼

Despite the new ways of thinking, Renaissance women were expected to stay at home. They were given little opportunity to study, though some who had privileged backgrounds became poets and writers.

An Italian noblewoman, Sofonisba Anguissola, was one of the few successful female Renaissance artists. She painted this portrait of her sisters playing chess in 1555.

